DR JITENDRA SINGH, 67 | BJP

Minister of State (Independent Charge) of Science & Technology; Earth Sciences

Early life Singh was born to a Hindu Dogra family of Jammu. An alumnus of The Scindia School, Gwalior, he went on to study medicine and was a professor of diabetes and endocrinology at the University of Jammu

Political turn His political journey began with active participation in the Amarnath land transfer case, at which time he quit his teaching job. He joined the BJP in 2012, and felled Ghulam Nabi Azad from Udhampur in 2014, then Vikramaditya Singh, grandson of Maharaja Hari Singh, in 2019. This is his third successive win from the seat

Current responsibilities Singh's role remains unchanged since 2014. He is also MoS in PMO and Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions besides Departments of Atomic Energy and Space. In his time, India has demonstrated its space prowess with missions to Mars and the Moon, besides enacting legislation to create the National Research Foundation as a supra-research funding agency for S&T breakthroughs and innovations



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

NEEDED, A QUANTUM LEAP National missions have been declared for critical and emerging technologies like AI, Quantum Computing, Green Hydrogen, Semiconductors and Bioeconomy. In 2023, the Anusandhan National Research Foundation was set up to foster a culture of research and innovation in India's universities, colleges, research institutions and R&D laboratories. The government has also pledged long-term funding of Rs 1 lakh crore in this year's interim budget. These need to be implemented rapidly and the funding, infrastructure, skill gaps filled

BUILD ON GAGANYAAN SUCCESS After successfully landing a spacecraft on the moon, India needs to successfully send a manned mission. It also needs to build reliable heavy-lift launchers to attain its goal of having a Bharatiya Antariksh Station

ENHANCE ATOMIC ENERGY CAPABILITIES Currently, India operates 22 nuclear power reactors with a total capacity of 6.8 GW, contributing about 3 per cent to the nation's energy mix. That contribution needs to go up, and its uses extended in fields such as agriculture, healthcare and space exploration

ENCOURAGE SPACE START-UPS India has been making attempts in the recent past to open up the largely state-run space economy. The Space Policy, 2023, and the setting up of the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorization Centre (In - SPACE), saw the spawning of 190 new space tech start-ups. India now needs to extend that to other disciplines